Case Study 1: Sunrise Digital Microfinance Bank

Designing a Customer Experience Automation Hub to Improve Onboarding, Activation and Customer Retention

Project: Customer Success and CX Automation Case Study
Industry: Financial Services / Digital Banking
My focus: Customer Journey Analysis | Customer Onboarding | Customer Activation | Service Recovery | Voice of Customer | Customer Operations
Project type: Research-led case study and proposed automation solution

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1. Executive Summary

Sunrise Digital Microfinance Bank was experiencing customer experience challenges across its digital onboarding journey, account activation, transaction support, and customer feedback management.

Research revealed that customers were abandoning onboarding at different stages, experiencing verification difficulties, struggling to understand account requirements, and encountering delays or uncertainty when transactions failed.

Another concern was the way customer feedback was managed. Feedback came from multiple channels, including customer care calls, app-store reviews, social media, and branch or agent interactions, but there was no centralised process for consolidating recurring issues and ensuring that they received appropriate attention.

I approached this challenge from a Customer Success Management perspective.

Rather than treating each complaint as an isolated support request, I examined the customer journey, reviewed the available evidence, identified potential root causes, prioritised customer pain points, and designed a connected Customer Experience Automation Hub.

The proposed solution consists of five interconnected areas:

1. Onboarding and Activation Recovery.
2. Transaction Status and Recovery.
3. Customer Support and Service Recovery.

4. Voice of Customer Management.
5. Customer Experience Performance and Insights.

The objective is to help Sunrise move from a largely reactive customer support approach towards a more proactive, measurable, and coordinated customer experience operation.

The central idea: Identify customer friction early, intervene appropriately, assign clear ownership, and confirm that the customer has achieved a successful outcome.

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2. Business Context and Problem Statement

Digital financial services depend on customer confidence.

Customers need to be able to register, verify their identities, understand their account options, fund their accounts, and complete transactions without unnecessary friction.

However, a customer who encounters difficulty during any of these stages may abandon the process, lose confidence in the service, or repeatedly contact customer support.

The research identified four broad challenges:

A. Onboarding and activation friction

Customers were dropping off at different stages of the onboarding journey. Some experienced lost verification sessions, repeated logouts, unclear requirements, and uncertainty about what to do next.

B. Weak customer communication

Some customers did not receive sufficient confirmation or guidance after completing important onboarding activities. This created uncertainty about whether their registration or documents had been received.

C. Transaction and support challenges

Customers reported failed or delayed transfers, delayed reversals, generic support responses, and a lack of follow-up.

D. Fragmented customer feedback

Customer feedback existed across several channels, but the business lacked a consistent way to consolidate, categorise, prioritise, assign, and track recurring customer problems.

These challenges were connected. A customer who struggles during onboarding may never become an active customer. A customer whose transaction issue remains unresolved may lose confidence in the bank. A customer whose feedback receives no meaningful response may eventually disengage.

My approach was therefore to examine the complete customer experience rather than focus on one isolated problem.

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3. Research and Customer Journey Analysis

3.1 Onboarding Funnel Analysis

The first step was to examine the available onboarding figures to identify where customers were experiencing the greatest drop-off.

Customer journey stage	Customers	Conversion from previous stage
App registration	42,600	100%
BVN/NIN verification	31,250	73%
Selfie/liveness verification	24,100	77%
Account tier and terms	19,870	82%
First deposit	9,340	47%
Active after 30 days	5,120	55%

What the data told me

1. Identity verification was an early onboarding challenge.

The bank lost 11,350 customers between registration and BVN/NIN verification. This was the largest absolute drop-off in the funnel.

This indicated a need to investigate the verification experience, including session interruptions, technical failures, and the clarity of instructions.

2. First deposit represented the largest proportional conversion decline.

Only 9,340 of the 19,870 customers who reached the account tier and terms stage proceeded to make a first deposit.

That represented a 47% conversion rate from the previous stage.

This suggested that the bank needed to investigate what prevented customers from progressing from account setup to funding.

Possible areas to investigate included:

- Understanding of account features and requirements.
- Clarity of funding instructions.
- Customer confidence in making the first deposit.
- Technical or payment-related difficulties.
- Availability of assistance when customers encountered problems.

The data did not establish which of these factors caused the drop-off.

3. Customer activation required attention after funding.

Of the 9,340 customers who made a first deposit, 5,120 met the 30-day activity definition of at least two transactions.

This represented approximately 55% of funded customers.

This highlighted the importance of supporting customers beyond account creation and first funding.

A successful onboarding process should help customers reach meaningful product usage, not simply complete registration.

3.2 Customer Feedback Analysis

I also considered customer stories and feedback from different channels.

Source	Research finding	Customer experience implication
Customer story: Tunde	Lost his verification session and abandoned the process	Interrupted onboarding needs a recovery path
Customer story: Chiamaka	Did not understand the account tier names	Account information needs simpler explanations
Customer story: Musa	Received no contact after registration and assumed the account had failed	Customers need clear milestone communication
Customer story: Grace	Did not receive confirmation after submitting documents	Important submissions need confirmation

Customer story: Emeka	Experienced a delayed transfer, received a generic support response, and did not receive adequate follow-up	Transaction cases need ownership and service recovery
Customer care	112 calls concerning transfers failing and money being held for hours before reversal	Transaction issues require operational investigation and escalation
App-store reviews	89 reviews mentioning repeated logouts or re-verification	Authentication and session issues need investigation
Instagram/X	260 comments, including requests for access to human support	Customers need a clear human assistance route
Branch/agent feedback	Older customers preferred assisted onboarding	Digital onboarding should accommodate customers who need additional guidance

The channel figures represent different types of feedback and may include duplicate experiences. They should not be treated as a deduplicated count of unique affected customers.

3.3 Key Customer Journey Gaps

Based on the funnel and customer feedback, I identified the following areas for improvement:

Journey stage	Identified gap	Potential customer impact
Registration	No clear recovery when customers abandon or interrupt the process	Abandoned registrations
Verification	Lost sessions and repeated verification	Frustration and repeated effort
Account selection	Unclear account tier explanations	Confusion and delayed decisions
Document submission	Missing confirmation	Uncertainty and repeated enquiries
Account creation	Inadequate communication after registration	Reduced confidence
First deposit	Significant conversion drop-off	Lower account activation
Transactions	Delayed or failed transfers and reversals	Reduced trust

Customer support	Generic responses and insufficient follow-up	Poor service recovery
Feedback management	Fragmented feedback sources	Recurring issues may remain unresolved

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4. My Root Cause Assessment

An important part of my approach was separating what the research confirmed from what still required investigation.

I did not want to recommend an automation simply because a particular problem appeared in a customer story.

Issue	What the research established	What needs further investigation
Verification abandonment	Significant drop-off and a customer story involving a lost session	Frequency and technical causes of session loss
Account tier confusion	A customer struggled to understand tier names	Whether this is widespread and how much it contributes to drop-off
Missing confirmation	Customers reported uncertainty after submitting information	Which confirmation messages are missing and at what stages
First deposit drop-off	Only 47% progressed from the previous funnel stage	Whether the main barriers are instructions, payment failures, confidence, or other factors
Transfer delays	Customers reported failed transfers and delayed reversals	Transaction-level causes, resolution times, and operational bottlenecks
Generic support	A customer described an inadequate response and lack of follow-up	Support processes, ownership, and escalation performance
Fragmented feedback	Feedback was distributed across several channels	Existing reporting processes and available integration options

This distinction matters because an effective Customer Success Manager must not confuse a symptom with its root cause.

For example, sending a reminder to a customer who cannot complete BVN verification will not resolve the underlying technical problem.

The intervention must match the actual reason the customer is unable to progress.

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5. My Customer Success Strategy

I structured the proposed solution around five objectives.

Objective 1: Help more customers complete onboarding

Customers should be able to recover from interruptions, understand requirements, and receive guidance at important stages.

Objective 2: Improve first-time activation

Customers should understand how to fund their accounts and complete their first meaningful transaction.

Objective 3: Improve transaction transparency and service recovery

Customers should receive accurate updates, know who is handling their issue, and have a clear path to resolution.

Objective 4: Make customer feedback actionable

Feedback should be consolidated, categorised, prioritised, assigned, and tracked until action is completed.

Objective 5: Establish measurable customer experience operations

The bank should be able to identify recurring problems, measure customer journey performance, and understand whether interventions are improving outcomes.

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6. Proposed Solution: Sunrise CX Automation Hub

I proposed a connected customer experience system with five functional areas.

6.1 Onboarding and Activation Recovery

Problem addressed

Customers may leave onboarding because of verification interruptions, unclear requirements, missing confirmations, or difficulty progressing to their first deposit.

Proposed customer journey

1. A customer starts registration.
2. The system records completed onboarding stages.
3. If registration remains incomplete beyond an agreed inactivity threshold, the customer becomes eligible for a recovery intervention.
4. The system checks the last completed stage and available recovery information.
5. An appropriate reminder is sent through a permitted communication channel.
6. When the customer returns, they authenticate and resume from the last valid step.
7. If the verification session has expired, the customer receives clear instructions for restarting that step.
8. Repeated failure or a request for assistance creates a support case.
9. The case is closed when onboarding is completed or another documented outcome is reached.

Additional improvements

- Plain-language explanations of account tiers.
- Clear account requirements and applicable limits.
- Confirmation after important submissions.
- Clear next-step instructions.
- First-deposit guidance.
- Human assistance for customers who need additional support.

Example customer communication

> Let's pick up where you left off.
>
> Your completed registration steps have been saved. You can continue from your last completed stage without starting the entire process again.
>
> If you need assistance, our support team is available to help.

Important operational consideration

Not every interruption should be classified as abandonment. The bank should define an appropriate inactivity threshold and account for verification sessions that may expire for security reasons.

Sensitive identity information must never be stored in an unsecured automation tool.

6.2 Transaction Status and Recovery

Problem addressed

Customers experience failed or delayed transfers and do not always receive clear information about the status or resolution of their transactions.

Proposed workflow

1. A transaction meets an agreed failed or delayed transaction rule.
2. The system retrieves the available transaction reference and status from an authorised source.
3. A support case is created with the relevant details.
4. The case is assigned to Payments or Operations.
5. The customer receives an update based on verified information.
6. If the case exceeds its agreed resolution or response threshold, it is escalated.
7. The responsible team updates the case with the investigation outcome.
8. The customer receives confirmation when the issue is resolved.
9. The case is closed only after the outcome has been confirmed.

Example customer communication

> We understand that your transfer has not been completed as expected.
>
> Your report has been received and is being reviewed by our Payments team. Your case reference is [Case Reference].
>
> We will provide an update as soon as verified information is available.

Service recovery principle

I would never design a workflow that tells a customer their money has been reversed simply because a notification was sent.

Transaction status must come from an authorised source, and unresolved cases must remain visible to the responsible team.

6.3 Customer Support and Service Recovery

Problem addressed

Customers may receive generic responses, repeat information, or fail to receive follow-up when an issue requires another team to resolve it.

Proposed improvement

Introduce a structured case management process.

Each case should contain:

- Customer reference.
- Issue category.
- Description of the problem.
- Date and time reported.
- Relevant transaction or onboarding reference.
- Severity or priority.
- Assigned team.
- Case owner.
- Next action.
- Agreed response or resolution deadline.
- Current status.
- Customer communication history.
- Resolution outcome.

Proposed case statuses

New → Assigned → In Progress → Pending Customer / Pending Internal Team → Escalated → Resolved → Closed.

Customers should not have to start from the beginning every time their case moves between teams.

The receiving team should have access to the relevant case history and previous actions.

6.4 Voice of Customer Management

Problem addressed

Feedback is spread across customer care, app-store reviews, social media, and branch or agent records.

Proposed solution

Create a central Voice of Customer (VoC) management process.

Workflow

1. Capture feedback from available channels.
2. Record the feedback source and date.
3. Categorise the issue.
4. Identify possible duplicates.
5. Group recurring feedback into themes.

6. Prioritise issues according to customer impact, severity, recurrence, and volume.
7. Assign each priority issue to an accountable team.
8. Track actions and deadlines.
9. Review whether the action resolved the underlying issue.
10. Communicate relevant outcomes to customers where appropriate.

Suggested feedback categories

- Registration.
- BVN/NIN verification.
- Selfie/liveness verification.
- Account tiers and requirements.
- Account creation.
- First deposit.
- Transfers and reversals.
- Account access and authentication.
- Customer support.
- Human assistance.
- General product feedback.

Example action tracker

Feedback theme	Priority	Responsible team	Required action	Success indicator
Verification sessions lost	High	Product / Engineering	Investigate session recovery	Fewer repeated failures
Unclear account tiers	Medium	Product / CX	Improve explanations	Fewer tier-related enquiries
Delayed transfers	High	Payments / Operations	Investigate delays and escalation process	Improved resolution performance
Missing submission confirmation	Medium	Product / CX	Review milestone messages	Fewer confirmation enquiries
Demand for human support	Medium	Customer Support	Improve human handoff	Better support accessibility

Priority levels should be validated against the bank's risk and incident management policies.

6.5 Customer Experience Performance and Insights

The fifth component brings information from the other workflows together.

The purpose is to help management understand:

- Where customers are dropping off.
- Which onboarding stages experience repeated failures.
- Which transaction issues occur most frequently.
- How quickly support cases are assigned and resolved.
- Which feedback themes require product or operational action.
- Whether customers resume onboarding after intervention.
- Whether customers become active after funding.

Suggested dashboard sections

1. Onboarding funnel.
2. Verification failure and recovery.
3. First-deposit conversion.
4. 30-day customer activation.
5. Transaction case performance.
6. Customer support performance.
7. Voice of Customer themes.
8. Outstanding improvement actions.

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7. Ownership and Cross-Functional Collaboration

Customer Success should coordinate the customer experience, but it should not assume responsibility for every technical or financial operation.

I proposed the following ownership model:

Activity	Accountable team	Customer Success contribution
Onboarding experience	Product / CX	Identify friction and monitor completion
Verification functionality	Product / Engineering	Track customer impact and communicate blockers
Account tier information	Product / Compliance	Help make explanations customer-friendly
First-deposit experience	Product / Payments	Monitor conversion and identify customer difficulties

Transaction investigation	Payments / Operations	Coordinate customer updates and case follow-up
Technical transaction issues	Engineering	Escalate verified technical patterns
Customer support	Customer Support / CX	Ensure clear ownership and customer communication
Feedback management	CX / Customer Success	Consolidate themes and track actions

The goal is to establish a clear process where each issue has an owner and customers are not left without updates.

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8. Measurement Framework

I would establish baseline measurements before setting performance targets.

Area	KPI	Measurement
Onboarding	Verification completion rate	Customers completing verification ÷ customers reaching the stage
Onboarding recovery	Recovery rate	Interrupted customers who resume ÷ eligible interrupted customers
Activation	First-deposit conversion	Customers making first deposit ÷ customers reaching account tier and terms
Activation	30-day active rate	Funded customers completing at least two transactions within 30 days ÷ funded customers
Transactions	Time to resolution	Time between case creation and confirmed resolution
Support	First response time	Time between case creation and first meaningful response
Support	Repeat contact rate	Customers contacting support again about the same issue
VoC	Feedback assignment rate	Categorised feedback assigned to an owner ÷ total eligible feedback

VoC	Action completion rate	Priority actions completed by deadline ÷ priority actions due
Customer experience	Post-resolution CSAT	Customer satisfaction following issue resolution

Existing baseline figures

- Registration-to-verification conversion: approximately 73%.
- Account tier/terms-to-first-deposit conversion: approximately 47%.
- Funded-to-30-day-active conversion: approximately 55%.

These are research baselines, not results of the proposed solution.

I would use them to establish improvement priorities and compare performance after implementation.

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9. Implementation Roadmap

I would recommend a phased implementation to avoid introducing too many changes at once.

Phase 1: Research Validation and Process Definition

- Validate the customer stories and feedback categories.
- Review onboarding and transaction data.
- Confirm the technical causes of key failures.
- Agree on case ownership and escalation responsibilities.
- Define inactivity thresholds and communication rules.
- Establish baseline KPIs.

Deliverable: Validated customer journey map and prioritised improvement backlog.

Phase 2: Prototype and Workflow Design

- Design the onboarding recovery journey.
- Design the transaction case workflow.
- Create the central feedback inbox.
- Define required customer and case fields.
- Design dashboard views.
- Build a clickable prototype and sample automation workflows.

Deliverable: Demonstrable CX Automation Hub prototype.

Phase 3: Controlled Pilot

- Test workflows with sample or approved pilot data.
- Validate reminders, case creation, assignment, and escalation.
- Test failure scenarios and duplicate handling.
- Confirm that customers receive accurate communication.
- Gather feedback from internal teams.

Deliverable: Pilot findings and recommended adjustments.

Phase 4: Rollout and Continuous Improvement

Subject to technical, compliance, and operational approval:

- Integrate with authorised bank systems.
- Roll out approved workflows.
- Train relevant support and operations teams.
- Monitor KPIs.
- Review recurring issues.
- Improve workflows based on measured results.

Deliverable: Operational customer experience workflows with ongoing performance monitoring.

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10. Risks and Controls

Risk	Why it matters	Proposed control
Insecure customer data handling	Banking and identity information is sensitive	Use approved systems and strict access controls
Incorrect transaction notifications	Can mislead customers about their money	Retrieve status from authorised transaction systems
Excessive reminders	May frustrate customers	Define consent-based communication and frequency limits
False inactivity alerts	May classify active customers incorrectly	Validate multiple signals and thresholds
Unclear ownership	Cases may remain unresolved	Assign an accountable owner and escalation path
Duplicate feedback	Can distort reporting	Apply duplicate detection and source tracking

Automation failures	Cases or notifications may be missed	Monitor workflow errors and maintain manual fallback processes

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11. Expected Business and Customer Impact

If implemented successfully, the proposed system is intended to:

- Reduce avoidable onboarding abandonment.
- Improve verification recovery.
- Make account requirements easier to understand.
- Improve first-deposit conversion.
- Increase the proportion of funded customers who become active.
- Improve transaction communication and service recovery.
- Reduce repeat enquiries caused by poor case follow-up.
- Make recurring customer feedback visible to decision-makers.
- Improve accountability across customer-facing and operational teams.

These are intended outcomes. No post-implementation results have been supplied, so they should not be presented as achieved improvements.

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12. What This Project Demonstrates About My Customer Success Approach

This project demonstrates how I approach customer experience problems beyond the immediate support interaction.

I started with the customer journey, used available data to identify friction, examined customer stories to understand the experience behind the numbers, and separated confirmed evidence from possible explanations.

I then translated those findings into practical workflows with clear ownership, customer communication, escalation rules, and measurable success indicators.

The most important lesson is that customer success is not simply about sending reminders, resolving tickets, or maintaining contact.

It is about helping customers achieve the outcomes they came for, ensuring that internal teams act on customer problems, and using feedback and data to improve the overall experience.

My approach in one sentence: Understand the friction, identify the right intervention, assign ownership, and measure whether the customer succeeds.

Project status: Research analysis and proposed solution. Automation workflows and integrations should be treated as prototypes until tested and deployed in an authorised environment.

Prototype: Sunrise Pocket

To demonstrate how the proposed customer experience solution could work, I designed a clickable app prototype in Figma.

The prototype illustrates the proposed customer journey, including key onboarding and account access experiences.

View the interactive prototype: Open Sunrise Pocket in Figma

Design focus:

- Simplifying the customer onboarding experience.
- Making verification steps easier to understand.
- Improving visibility of the customer's onboarding progress.
- Providing clearer guidance at important points in the customer journey.

Project status: Conceptual prototype developed as part of a Customer Success and Experience case study. It is not a live banking application.